

Nefertiti

Location: The **Hall of the Lost Dynasties**

Nefertiti (circa 1370 – circa 1330 BC) was a queen of the 18th Dynasty of Ancient Egypt and the Great Royal Wife of Pharaoh Akhenaten. Nefertiti and her husband were known for their radical overhaul of state religious policy, promoting an exclusivist religion, Atenism, centered on the sun disc and its direct connection to the royal household. With her husband, she reigned during what was arguably the wealthiest period of ancient Egyptian history.

After her husband's death, some scholars believe that Nefertiti ruled briefly as a female pharaoh known by the throne name Neferneferuaten just before the ascension of Tutankhamun, though this identification remains a matter of ongoing debate. If Nefertiti did rule as pharaoh, her reign was marked by the fall of Amarna and the relocation of the capital back to the traditional city of Memphis after her death.

In the 20th century, Nefertiti was made famous by the discovery and display of her ancient bust, now in Berlin's Neues Museum. The bust is one of the most copied works of the art of ancient Egypt. It is attributed to the Egyptian sculptor Thutmose and was excavated from his studio complex in the early 20th century.

Names and Titles

Nefertiti held many official titles, including:

- **Neferneferuaten** ("Beautiful is the beauty of Aten")
- **Hereditary Princess**
- **Great of Praises**
- **Lady of Grace**
- **Sweet of Love**
- **Lady of The Two Lands**
- **Main King's Wife, his beloved**
- **Great King's Wife, his beloved**
- **Lady of All Women**
- **Mistress of Upper & Lower Egypt**

While modern Egyptological pronunciation renders her name as Nefertiti, her original name meant "the beautiful one has come" and was likely contemporarily pronounced Naftita or Nafrat-ita.

Family and Early Life

Almost nothing is known about Nefertiti's life before her marriage to Akhenaten. Scenes from the tombs of the nobles in Amarna mention that Nefertiti had a sister named Mutbenret. Further, a woman named Tey carried the title of "Nurse of the Great Royal Wife." Tey's husband, Ay, held the title "God's Father," which some Egyptologists believe was used for a man whose daughter married the pharaoh. Based on these titles, it has been proposed that Ay was Nefertiti's father, though neither Ay nor Tey are explicitly referred to as her parents in surviving sources. Another variation of this theory suggests Nefertiti was the daughter of Ay by a first wife who died, making Tey her stepmother.

It has also been proposed that Nefertiti was Akhenaten's full sister, though this is contradicted by her titles, which lack "King's Daughter" or "King's Sister." Another theory identified Nefertiti with the Mitanni princess Tadukhipa, interpreting her name ("The Beautiful Woman has Come") as indicating foreign origins. However, Tadukhipa was already married to Akhenaten's father, Amenhotep III, and there is no evidence why she would change her name or that Nefertiti was of non-Egyptian origin.

The exact dates when Nefertiti married Akhenaten and became Great Royal Wife are uncertain. They had at least six daughters together:

1. Meritaten
2. Meketaten
3. Ankhesenpaaten (later Ankhesenamun, wife of Tutankhamun)
4. Neferneferuaten Tasherit
5. Neferneferure
6. Setepenre

She was once considered a candidate for the mother of Tutankhamun, but genetic testing conducted on mummies suggests she was not.

Life and Reign

Nefertiti first appears in relief scenes in Thebes. In the tomb of the royal butler Parennefer, Amenhotep IV is accompanied by a royal lady believed to be an early depiction of Nefertiti worshipping the Aten. In the tomb of the vizier Ramose, she stands behind her husband in the Window of Appearance.

During the early years in Thebes, Akhenaten had several temples erected at Karnak. One structure, the Mansion of the Benben, was dedicated specifically to Nefertiti, where she is depicted alongside her daughters Meritaten and Meketaten. In scenes preserved on talatat stone blocks from the first five years of the reign, Nefertiti is depicted almost twice as frequently as her husband, demonstrating her political importance. She is shown in traditional royal roles as well as actions reserved strictly for the king, such as smiting captivity enemies and featuring captive enemies on her throne.

In the fourth year of his reign, Amenhotep IV decided to move the capital to Akhetaten (modern Amarna). In his fifth year, he officially changed his name to Akhenaten, and Nefertiti became known as Neferneferuaten-Nefertiti, signaling the growing importance of the Aten cult.

Boundary stelae from years 4 and 5 mark the borders of the new capital. Nefertiti and her family resided in the Great Royal Palace at the center of the city and possibly the Northern Palace. Her household steward was an official named Meryre II.

Inscriptions in the tombs of Huya and Meryre II dated to Year 12, 2nd month of Peret, Day 8 show a foreign tribute ceremony where representatives from Kharu (the north) and Kush (the south) brought gifts to Akhenaten and Nefertiti, who sat in a kiosk attended by their six daughters. This is one of the last times princess Meketaten is depicted alive; she likely died in Year 13 or 14, with reliefs showing Nefertiti, Akhenaten, and three princesses mourning her.

Two excavated representations by Flinders Petrie—a preliminary limestone sketch wearing her distinctive tall crown and a reddish-brown quartzite inlay head—show Nefertiti in the middle to later part of the reign.

The last dated inscription naming Nefertiti and Akhenaten comes from a limestone quarry building inscription at Deir Abu Hinnis, dating to Year 16 of the king's reign. Akhenaten died shortly after in his 17th regnal year.

Possible Reign as Pharaoh

Many scholars believe Nefertiti was promoted to co-regent by Akhenaten before his death. She is depicted across archaeological sites equal in stature to a king—smiting enemies, riding chariots, and worshipping the Aten as a pharaoh.

When Nefertiti's name disappears from records, it is replaced by a co-regent named Neferneferuaten, who became a female pharaoh. It seems likely that Nefertiti assumed the kingship under the throne name Neferneferuaten after Akhenaten's death before being succeeded by Tutankhamun. (It is considered less likely that she assumed a male identity as Smenkhkare, who is thought to have been a separate co-regent who died earlier).

If Nefertiti ruled as pharaoh, she may have attempted damage control by restoring elements of traditional Egyptian religion, reinstating the priests of Amun, and raising Tutankhamun in the worship of the traditional gods. Archaeologist Zahi Hawass theorized that Nefertiti returned to Thebes to rule, citing feminine ushabtis and queenly evidence in Tutankhamun's tomb.

Disproved Theories

Pre-2012 theories assumed Nefertiti disappeared or died around Year 12 of Akhenaten's reign due to plague or injury, based on ushabti fragments inscribed for her. An older theory that she fell into disgrace was discredited when the erased monuments in question were shown to belong to Akhenaten's secondary wife, Kiya.

Instead, evidence indicates Nefertiti held unprecedented power throughout Akhenaten's reign, likely being elevated to full co-regent status by Year 12.

Here is the complete, clean version of this section on the new theories regarding Nefertiti's career as a pharaoh, as well as her death and burial. All citation brackets, footnotes, phonetic symbols, and formatting artifacts have been removed, while every single date, name, quote, inscription translation, line-by-line argument, scholar's perspective, and archaeological detail has been fully preserved.

New Theories About Nefertiti's Career as a Pharaoh

In 2012, the discovery of an inscription dated to Year 16, month 3 of Akhet, day 15 of the reign of Akhenaten was announced. It was discovered within Quarry 320 in the largest wadi of the limestone quarry project at Dayr Abu Hinnis. The five-line inscription, written in red ochre ink, mentions the presence of the "Great Royal Wife, His Beloved, Mistress of the Two Lands, Neferneferuaten Nefertiti". The final line of the inscription refers to ongoing building work being carried out under the authority of the king's scribe Penthu on the Small Aten Temple in Amarna.

The Year 16 ink inscription was translated as:

"Regnal year 16, first month of the inundation season, day 15. May the King of Upper and Lower Egypt live, he who lives of Maat, the Lord of the Two Lands Neferkheperure Waenre, l.p.h. the Son of Re, who lives of Maat, the Lord of the Crowns Akhenaten, l.p.h., whose life span is long, living forever and ever, the King's Great Wife, his beloved, the lady of the two lands Neferneferuaten-Nefertiti, living forever and ever. Beloved of Re, the ruler of the two horizons, who rejoices in the horizon in his name of Re ///, who comes as the Aten. the /// the work of the Mansion of the Aten, under the authority of the king's scribe Penthu, under the authority of overseer of work///."

Athena van der Perre stresses that:

"This inscription offers incontrovertible evidence that both Akhenaten and Nefertiti were still alive in the 16th year of his [Akhenaten's] reign and, more importantly, that they were still holding the same positions as at the start of their reign. This makes it necessary to rethink the final years of the Amarna Period."

This means that Nefertiti was alive in the second to last year of Akhenaten's reign, and demonstrates that Akhenaten still ruled alone, with his wife by his side. Therefore, the rule of the female Amarna pharaoh known as Neferneferuaten must be placed between the death of Akhenaten and the accession of Tutankhamun. Neferneferuaten, the female pharaoh, specifically used the epithet "Effective for her husband" in one of her cartouches, which means she was either Nefertiti or her daughter Meritaten (who was married to king Smenkhkare). Moreover,

unlike Meritaten, Nefertiti had already used the title "Neferneferuaten" by Year 5 of Akhenaten's reign in her own cartouches.

The number of Egyptologists who today agree that the female pharaoh Neferneferuaten was Nefertiti include Chris Naunton, Aidan Dodson, Athena van der Perre, Nozomu Kawai, and James Peter Allen since 2016 in a Göttinger Miszellen article.

In his updated 2016 paper, James P. Allen now also identifies the female pharaoh as Neferneferuaten Nefertiti, and not Akhenaten's daughter who was named Neferneferuaten Tasherit (the younger) as he had previously suggested in a 2009 paper in memory of the late William J. Murnane. Allen states:

"The evidence indicates Smenkhkare ruled only about a year at most....Smenkhkare's premature death probably no later than Akhenaten's Regnal Year 14 left only the one-to-four year old heir Tutankhuaten as putative heir....Tutankhamun must have been considered too young to be named coregent in his father's stead....To safeguard Tutankhamun's accession, Akhenaten also appointed a female coregent Ankheperure Neferneferuaten, to oversee the transition and probably to instruct him in the new religion. In 2009, I argued that this coregent was Akhenaten's fourth daughter, Neferneferuaten, both because it seemed a logical progression in his attempts to produce a son within each of his daughters as they reached puberty, and because evidence was lacking that the other Neferneferuaten, Nefertiti, was still alive in Akhenaten's final years. The Year 16 inscription noted [for the existence of Akhenaten's chief queen] at the beginning of this article solves the latter problem, and I (and my students) now think it likeliest that the coregent was in fact, Nefertiti. The arguments for this are more compelling than they are for the daughter.....Since Nefertiti was still chief queen in Regnal Year 16 [of Akhenaten], her Year 3 as pharaoh must have occurred two years after Akhenaten's death, and it was within those two years that the first steps towards reconciliation with Amun occurred. While little is known about the daughter other than her existence, Nefertiti had assumed pharaonic roles and prerogatives throughout Akhenaten's reign, and the occasional epithet in her nomen Akhet-en-hyes 'Beneficial for her husband,' both reflects a relationship that had already existed and mirrors Akhenaten's own nomen [Akh-en-Iten or 'The one who is beneficial to the Aten'], which described his relationship not only with his god but also with his predecessor, the Tjehen-Aten 'dazzling Aten,' Amenhotep III. Moreover, if as now seems probable, the appointment of a female coregent was intended not to ensure her own succession but that of the young Tutankhuaten, then it is far more likely that Akhenaten would have turned to the older more experienced woman who had served as his virtual co-ruler than to a young daughter who had just reached puberty barely three to six years older than the heir she was intended to safeguard."

Death and Burial

If, as seems likely, Nefertiti was the female pharaoh ruler named Neferneferuaten, she outlived her husband Akhenaten and held great influence over the royal family. If this is the case, that influence and presumably Nefertiti's own life would have ended by Year 3 of Tutankhamun's reign when she died and the Boy King succeeded her (1331 BC). In that year, Tutankhamun changed his name to Tutankhamun, which is interpreted as evidence of his return to the official

worship of Amun, and abandoned Amarna to return the capital to Memphis and Thebes according to Aidan Dodson.

Other Egyptologists such as Athena van der Perre and Nozomu Kawai conclude that Nefertiti had an independent or sole rule and was not Tutankhamun's senior co-regent on the throne. Kawai states:

"The fact that a number of objects found in Tutankhamun's tomb had been made for the burial of Neferneferuaten [Nefertiti here], adapted and reinscribed for Tutankhamun's use, implies that Tutankhaten and his entourage did not want to recognize the preceding reign. Neferneferaten had assumed sole reign despite the fact that Tutankhaten, the crown prince, was the legitimate successor [to Akhenaten]. Instead of giving up her kingship to a young boy, Neferneferuaten may have wished to continue her sole rule not only because she was already reigning, but also because Tutankhaten was just a boy between five and 10 years old. Although Neferneferuaten began restoring the cults of Amun and other deities she also simultaneously maintained the cult of Aten at Amarna, resulting in a dissatisfied faction of [royal] officials [such as Ay and Horemheb] and priests who advocated a quick return to orthodoxy."

Nefertiti's burial was intended to be made within the Royal Tomb as laid out in the Boundary Stelae. It is possible that the unfinished annex of the Royal Tomb was intended for her use. However, given that Akhenaten appears to have predeceased her, it is highly unlikely she was ever buried there. One shabti is known to have been made for her. The unfinished Tomb 29, which would have been of very similar dimensions to the Royal Tomb had it been finished, is the most likely candidate for a tomb begun for Nefertiti's exclusive use. Given that it lacks a burial chamber, she was not interred there either.

Possible Mummy Identification Theories

In 1898, French archaeologist Victor Loret found two female mummies among those cached inside the tomb of Amenhotep II in KV35 in the Valley of the Kings. These two mummies, known as 'The Elder Lady' and 'The Younger Lady', were identified as likely candidates of her remains:

- **The Elder Lady:** An article in KMT magazine in 2001 suggested that the Elder Lady might be Nefertiti. However, it was subsequently shown that the Elder Lady is in fact Tiye, mother of Akhenaten. A lock of hair found in a coffinet bearing an inscription naming Queen Tiye proved a near perfect match to the hair of the Elder Lady. DNA analysis confirmed that she was the daughter of Tiye's parents Yuya and Thuya.
- **The Younger Lady:** On 9 June 2003, archaeologist Joann Fletcher, a specialist in ancient hair from the University of York in England, announced that Nefertiti's mummy may have been the Younger Lady. This theory was criticised by Zahi Hawass and several other Egyptologists. In a subsequent research project led by Hawass, the mummy was put through CT scan analysis and DNA analysis. Researchers concluded that she was Tutankhamun's biological mother, an unnamed daughter of Amenhotep III and Tiye, not Nefertiti.

In 2015, English archaeologist Nicholas Reeves announced that high resolution scans revealed voids behind the walls of Tutankhamun's tomb which he proposed to be the burial chamber of Nefertiti, but subsequent radar scans showed that there are no hidden chambers.

KV21B Mummy

One of the two female mummies found in KV21 has been suggested as the body of Nefertiti. DNA analysis did not yield enough data to make a definitive identification but confirmed she was a member of the Eighteenth Dynasty royal line.

CT-scanning revealed she was about 45 at the time of her death; her left arm had been bent over her chest in the 'queenly' pose. The possible identification is based on her association with the mummy tentatively identified as Ankhesenamun. It is suggested that just as a mother and daughter (Tiye and the Younger Lady) were found lying together in KV35, the same was true of these mummies.

Summary:

Birth, Names & Titles

- **Estimated Birth Year:** Circa 1370 BCE.
- **Estimated Age at Death:** Approximately 40 to 45 years old (c. 1330 BCE or 1331 BCE).
- **Name Meaning:** *Nfr.t-jy.tj* ("The beautiful one has come"), contemporarily pronounced *Naftita* or *Nafrat-ita*.
- **Extended Name:** Adopted the name **Neferneferuaten-Nefertiti** ("Beautiful is the beauty of Aten, the beautiful one has come") around Regnal Year 5 of Akhenaten's reign.
- **Royal & Sacred Titles:**
 - Great King's Wife, his beloved (*hmt-nswt-wrt mrt.f*)
 - Mistress of Upper & Lower Egypt (*hnwt-šm³w-mḥw*)
 - Lady of The Two Lands (*nbt-t³wj*)
 - Hereditary Princess (*iryt-p³t*)
 - Great of Praises, Lady of Grace, Sweet of Love, Lady of All Women

Family & Lineage

- **Parents (Theories):**
 - **Most Likely:** Daughter of **Ay** (a high official, later Pharaoh) by an unnamed first wife who died, making Ay's second wife, **Tey** ("Nurse of the Great Royal Wife"), her stepmother.
 - **Alternative Hypotheses:** Foreign origin as the Mitanni princess *Tadukhipa* (generally dismissed), or a full/half sister of Akhenaten (contradicted by the absence of titles like "King's Daughter").
- **Siblings:** Had a known sister named **Mutbenret**.
- **Husband:** Pharaoh **Akhenaten** (formerly Amenhotep IV).

- **Daughters (6 with Akhenaten):**
 1. **Meritaten:** Eldest daughter, later Great Royal Wife to Smenkhkare.
 2. **Meketaten:** Died young around Regnal Year 13–14.
 3. **Ankhesenpaaten:** Later renamed *Ankhesenamun*, Great Royal Wife to Tutankhamun.
 4. **Neferneferuaten Tasherit**
 5. **Neferneferure**
 6. **Setepenre**
- **Maternal Status:** Genetic testing confirms she was **not** the biological mother of Tutankhamun (his mother was a biological sister of Akhenaten known as "The Younger Lady").

Status, Political Role & Career

- **Prominence in Imagery:** Depicted on *talatat* blocks from the first five years of Akhenaten's reign almost twice as often as her husband.
- **Pharaonic Regalia:** Rendered performing actions traditionally exclusive to male pharaohs—riding war chariots, smiting captive enemies, wearing royal crowns (including her iconic flat-topped blue crown), and featuring bound captives on her throne.
- **Dedication of Temples:** Had specific monumental structures dedicated to her, such as the *Mansion of the Benben* (*Hwt-ben-ben*) at Karnak.
- **Reign as Pharaoh (Neferneferuaten):** Modern consensus among many Egyptologists (including Aidan Dodson, Athena van der Perre, and James P. Allen) indicates she survived Akhenaten, ruled as sole female pharaoh under the throne name **Ankheperure Neferneferuaten** for roughly 2 to 3 years, and oversaw early steps toward restoring traditional religious order before Tutankhamun took the throne.

Death & Mummy Identification Status

- **Intended Burial Sites:** Originally planned to be buried in the Royal Tomb at Akhetaten (Amarna) or Tomb 29; neither tomb was completed for her use due to Akhenaten predeceasing her and the city being abandoned.
- **Candidate Mummies:**
 - **The Elder Lady (KV35):** Disproved (confirmed via DNA to be Queen Tiye).
 - **The Younger Lady (KV35):** Disproved (confirmed via DNA to be Tutankhamun's biological mother and Akhenaten's full sister).
 - **KV21B:** A female mummy found in tomb KV21, aged around 45 with her left arm fixed in a "queenly" pose over her chest; remains a candidate, though current DNA data is inconclusive.